The Lift

Genre: Contemporary fiction / Psychological realism

Themes: Isolation, choices, urban loneliness, empathy, silent connections

1. First Floor

Ravi had lived in Flat 1B for six years, and still didn't know the name of the woman in 4C.

He didn't need to. Like most residents of Gulmohar Heights, he lived inside routines: wake up, work, order dinner, scroll mindlessly, sleep. The lift was a passing space, not a place for conversation.

But that Monday morning, the lift didn't move.

Ravi pressed the button again. Nothing. He sighed and turned, nearly bumping into someone.

It was the woman from 4C.

"I think it's stuck," she said. "Again."

Ravi smiled awkwardly. "Of course. Monday curse."

They stood in silence.

"Should we take the stairs?" she asked.

"I guess."

They began climbing, step by step.

2. Second Floor

He offered to carry her groceries.

"You don't have to," she said.

"I don't mind."

They walked up two flights, slowly. He noticed she paused a little too long between floors.

"You okay?" he asked.

"Just asthma. It's mild. Comes and goes."

Silence again. But this time, it wasn't awkward.

“What do you do?” she asked.

“Work from home. IT. Mostly automate things no one understands.”

She laughed—a soft, dry laugh.

“I’m a school counselor,” she said. “Mostly talk to kids who don't talk back.”

They reached the second floor.

A child cried somewhere.

“Ironic,” she muttered.

3. Third Floor

“Married?” she asked, breaking the quiet.

“No,” he said. “You?”

“No.”

Another pause.

He didn’t ask why. She didn’t explain.

The air felt heavier, not with discomfort—but with thoughts unsaid.

“Ever wonder,” she said, “if people in apartments above us live completely different lives? Or the same ones, just on higher floors?”

Ravi smiled. “Depends if they have working lifts.”

She gave him a look. “Bad joke.”

“I try.”

4. Fourth Floor

They reached her door.

“You made it,” Ravi said.

“Barely.”

She turned to unlock the door, then stopped.

“You’re always quiet,” she said.

“So are you.”

“I’m quiet because I see too much.”

“I’m quiet because I feel too little.”

She looked at him for a moment that felt longer than it was.

“You want tea?” she asked.

He hesitated, then nodded.

5. The Cup

The house smelled like old books and mild detergent.

She served tea in chipped mugs. No sugar.

“I don’t usually invite people in,” she said.

“I don’t usually say yes.”

They sipped in silence.

On the wall, he noticed framed sketches—children’s drawings. One had a sun with human eyes. Another said “Sorry Miss, I cried today.”

“From your students?” he asked.

She nodded. “Sometimes they talk without speaking.”

He understood that.

6. Broken Things

The lift was repaired the next day.

But Ravi found himself using the stairs more often.

Sometimes, they met mid-way.

Sometimes, not at all.

She told him once that she’d had a fiancé, long ago. That he had left quietly, the way she expected most people to.

He told her he once loved someone too, but let her go because he thought silence was easier than love.

Neither judged.

7. Weeks Later

They were in the lift again. Functioning. Clean.

She pressed 4. He pressed 1.

The silence between them wasn't uncomfortable now.

He turned to her just before the door opened.

"You never told me your name."

"Smita."

"I'm Ravi."

The door slid open.

"Next time," she said, "I'll bring sugar."

He smiled. "I'll take the stairs."

Teaching Activities / Discussion Prompts

1. Character Analysis

- How do Ravi and Smita evolve through the story?

- What does silence symbolize for each?

2. Psychological Themes

- Urban isolation vs. quiet connection

- Unspoken trauma and healing through empathy

3. Moral Questions

- Is it okay to withdraw from the world after pain?

- Can fleeting connections be as real as long ones?

4. Creative Response

- Rewrite the story from Smita's perspective.

- Write an imagined scene one year later.